



PROGRAMME OF THE

15th

EAST AFRICA HIGHER EDUCATION QUALITY ASSURANCE FORUM AND CONFERENCE

Organized by the Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA), the East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Network (EAQAN), and Higher Education Council (HEC),
Rwanda

7th to 10th September 2026 in Kigali, Rwanda

Venue: Kigali Serena Hotel

THEME:

**TRANSFORMING QUALITY ASSURANCE
FOR FUTURE-READY HIGHER
EDUCATION SYSTEMS IN EAST AFRICA**



Hon. Joseph Nsengimana
Minister of Education



Prof. Idris A. Rai
Ag Executive Secretary of IUCEA



Dr. Edward Kadozi
Director General
Higher Education Council (HEC)



Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki
President,
East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Network



Prof. Michael Mawa
Senior Principal Quality Assurance & Qualifications
Framework, Inter- University Council for East Africa &
Chairman, 15th EAQAN Organizing Committee



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FORUM OVERVIEW

The transformation of higher education in East Africa is unfolding within a rapidly changing global environment marked by digital disruption, evolving labour market demands, and growing expectations for accountability, relevance, and inclusivity. In response to these developments, the Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA), working in partnership with National Quality Assurance Agencies (national commissions and councils for higher education) and the East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Network (EAQAN), has spearheaded initiatives to harmonise higher education systems across the region through common frameworks, policies, and collaborative programmes. A cornerstone of these efforts is the establishment of the East African Common Higher Education Area, which aims to align curricula, quality assurance systems, and qualifications to promote comparability, compatibility, and mutual recognition among the East African Partner States.

The 15th East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Forum and Conference, themed '*Transforming Quality Assurance for Future-Ready Higher Education Systems in East Africa*' is timely in addressing these emerging issues in higher education. The forum and conference provides a platform for dialogue, collaboration, networking and capacity building among higher education stakeholders, including the Inter-University Council for East Africa, Councils and Commission in-charge of Higher Education in the partner states, university leaders, quality assurance practitioners, policymakers, and development partners. The forum's activities include keynote addresses by experts, paper presentations on transformative practices, panel discussions, training and capacity building workshops, and high-level dialogues involving university leaders and government officials. These conversations aim to shape policies, foster innovation, and reinforce partnerships that will define the future of quality higher education in the region.



THEME OF THE FORUM

Transforming Quality Assurance for Future-Ready Higher Education Systems in East Africa.

SUB-THEMES OF THE FORUM

The 15th Annual East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Forum and Conference has the following Sub-Themes:

1. Leveraging Digital Transformation and AI for Data-Driven Quality Assurance Systems.
2. Leveraging Micro-Credentials and Alternative Credentials to Advance Lifelong Learning Ecosystems within National and Regional Frameworks.
3. Strengthening Recognition, Mobility, and Integration in the East African Higher Education Area.

TARGET PARTICIPANTS

The target participants for this Forum and Conference are the Quality Assurance Coordinators/ Directors/ Officers from Universities; Academicians; University Researchers; University Administrators; Executives, Directors/Secretaries of National Accreditations Agencies, regional National Quality Assurance Agencies (national Commissions and Councils for higher education), Policy makers, industry players, professional bodies, students and student unions and other higher education stakeholders.

PROGRAMME OF THE FORUM AND CONFERENCE

Sunday, 6th September 2026

Arrival of Participants in Kigali, Rwanda

DAY 1: Monday, 7th September 2026

08:00 – 09:00 Registration of Participants

Session 1: Official Opening of the 15th EAQA Forum



Master of Ceremony: Prof. Michael Mawa, The Chief Principal, Quality Assurance & Qualifications Framework, Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA)

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|---------------|--|
| 09:00 – 10:30 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> o Anthems <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Rwanda • East African Community o IUCEA Prayer o Announcements o Introduction of Participants o Welcome remarks by Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki, President, EAQAN o Remarks by Elizabeth Colucci, Representative of OBREAL Global Observatory and Coordinator of the HAQAA Initiative o Remarks by Dr. Dorothee Weyler, Regional Director, DAAD o Remarks by Dr. Edward Kadozi, Director General, Higher Education Council (HEC), Rwanda o Remarks by Prof. Idris Rai, Acting Executive Secretary, IUCEA o Official Opening Speech by Guest of Honour: Honorable Minister Joseph Nsengimana, Minister of Education, Rwanda |
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10:30 – 10:45	Group Photo
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10:45 – 11:15	Health Break and Networking
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High-Level Quality Assurance Dialogue Event

Session 2: Keynote Presentation and Panel Discussion

Chairperson: Prof. Mike Kuria, CEO, Commission for University, Kenya

11:15 – 11:45	Sub-Theme Three: Strengthening Recognition, Mobility, and Integration in the East African Common Higher Education Area
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1st Keynote Speaker: Ms. Siyao Wang, Project Officer for Higher Education at the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO's) Regional Office for Eastern Africa (ROEA).



11:45 – 13:00	Strengthening Recognition, Mobility, and Integration in the East African Common Higher Education Area Panel Discussion Panelist 1: Prof. Mary J. N. Okwakol, Executive Director, National Council for Higher Education, Uganda Panelist 2: Dr. Baribeshya Jean Bosco, Vice Chancellor, INES Ruhengari, Rwanda (<i>IUCEA Mobility programme</i>) Panelist 3: Prof. Didas Kayihura, Vice Chancellor, University of Rwanda, Rwanda (<i>Internship and Work placement Mobility Opportunities within EAC and beyond</i>) Panelist 4: Dr. Mukirae Njihia, Kenyatta University, Kenya – (<i>Beneficiary, IUCEA Staff Mobility programme</i>) Discussion
13:00 – 14:00	Lunch Break and Networking
Session 3	Chairperson: Prof. Raphael Nyonje, President, KuQAN
14: 00 – 15:00	Sub-Theme Three: Strengthening Integration in the East African Common Higher Education Area Survey Finding on the Implementation of the Framework for operationalization of the East African Common Higher Education Area Prof. Michael Mawa, The Chief Principal, Quality Assurance & Qualifications Framework, IUCEA Discussion
Session 4	Chairperson: Apiyo Okwiri, HAQAA3 General Coordination Team
15:00 – 16:30	Panel Discussion African Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance (ASG-QA): practical implementation and experience sharing HAQAA3 Training Graduate: Willy Mukobanya, Head of Quality Assurance Kigali Independent University ULK and Josephine



Uwamahoro, Quality Assurance & Compliance Officer, University of Technology and Arts of Byumba (UTAB)

- ASG-QA Dissemination Project – Prof. Eunice Marete, Commission for University Education, Kenya
- HAQAA3 agency review expert – Prof. Rachel Akimana, University of Burundi
- HAQAA3 mapping project – Mr. Abdou Cisse, RAFANAQ
- HAQAA3 ACTS Expert Team, Anglophone Cluster Dr. Robert Ayine, IUCEA

PAQAA – Continental quality assurance in Africa by PAQAA Advisor:
Dr. Abdallah Baguma

17:00 – 17:30	Health Break and Networking
18:00 – 21:00	Gala Dinner, Cultural Performance and Networking

End of Day 1

DAY 2: Tuesday, 8th September 2026

08:00 – 09:00 Registration of Participants

Session 5 Keynote Presentation

9:00 – 11:00

Chairperson: Prof. Mary Maurice N. Mukokoma, President, UUQAF
Sub-Theme One: Leveraging Digital Transformation and AI for Data-Driven Quality Assurance Systems

2nd Keynote Speaker: Dr. Diana Andone - Director of the Digital Education and Distance Education Department of Politehnica University of Timisoara, Romania – *Virtual*

3rd Keynote Speaker: Prof. Madara Ogot, UbuntuNet Alliance for Research and Education Networking

Discussion



11:00 – 11:15	Health Break and Networking
Session 6	Panel Discussion
11:15 – 13:00	Chairperson: Rev. Prof. Nathan H. Chiroma, Vice Chancellor, Africa College of Theology, Rwanda Leveraging Digital Transformation and AI for Data-Driven Internal and External Quality Assurance Systems Panelist 1: Dr. Edward Kadozi, Director General, Higher Education Council (HEC), Rwanda Panelist 2: Prof. Mike Kuria, Chief Executive Officer/ Commission Secretary, Commission for University Education, Kenya Panelist 3: Prof. John Mugisha, Vice Chancellor, Bishop Stuart University, Uganda Panelist 4: Prof. William J. Mwegoha, Vice Chancellor, Mzumbe University, Tanzania Paper Presentation: Integrating AI in curriculum design and delivery: lessons for quality assurance practitioners in East African universities by Catherine Laura Mamuli and Raphael Ondeko Nyonje, Open University of Kenya
13:00 – 14:00	Lunch Break and Networking
Session 7	Excursion to the Kigali Genocide Memorial
14:00	
End of Day 2	
DAY 3: Wednesday, 9th September, 2026	
08:00 – 08:30	Registration of Participants
Session 8	Keynote Presentation
08:30 – 10:00	Chairperson: Prof. Shadrack Sabai, President, TUQAF



Sub-Theme Two: Leveraging Micro-Credentials and Alternative Credentials to Advance Lifelong Learning Ecosystems within National and Regional Frameworks.

4th Keynote Speaker: Prof. Dr. Anca-Luminița Greere, Babeș Bolyai, Chaired Working Group of the European Association for Quality Assurance in Higher Education (ENQA) on the Quality Assurance of Micro-Credentials

Paper Presentation: Architecting Trust and Agility: Integrating Micro-credentials and Recognition of Prior Learning into the Kenya National Qualifications Framework for Dynamic Workforce Reskilling by Dr. Christine Kananu Gitonga, Zetech University, Kenya

10:00 – 10:30	Health break and Networking
Session 9	Chairperson: Prof. Rachel Akimana – President, Burundi Chapter
10:30 – 13:00	Paper Presentations: Sub-Theme Three: Strengthening Recognition, Mobility, and Integration in the East African Higher Education Area. i. Student Mobility and Cross-Border Enrollment in Rwanda’s Hospitality and Tourism institutions of Higher Learning: Drivers, Experiences, and Policy Implications by Denys Uwimpuhwe, Abudallah Baguma, and Lazaro Maniraguha, University of Tourism Technology and Business Studies (UTB) ii. Strengthening Recognition, Academic Mobility, and Regional Integration in the East African Higher Education Area: Progress, Challenges, and Future Directions by Dr. Jacklyne Okello Alari and Dr. Linda Ouma.
	Discussion
13:00 – 14:00	Lunch Break and Networking
Session 10	Presentation and Adoption of the Resolutions of the High-Level
14:00 – 15:00	Dialogue



Session 11	Closing Ceremony High-Level Quality Assurance Dialogue Event
15:00 – 16:30	Chairperson- Prof. Michael Mawa - o Statement from Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki, President, EAQAN - o Statement from Dr. Edward Kadozi, Director General, HEC, Rwanda - o Vote of Thanks – QA Director appointed by the EAQAN Members - o Closing Remarks by Idris Rai, Acting Executive Secretary, IUCEA
16:30 – 17:00	Health Break and Networking

End of Day 3 and Departure of the Vice Chancellors

DAY 4: Thursday, 10th September 2026

Parallel Sessions

1. Meeting of CEOs of the National Councils and Commissions, and
2. The 14th EAQAN General Assembly

08:00 – 08:30	Registration of Participants
Session 12	The 14th East African Higher Education Quality Assurance Network General Assembly
	Chairperson: Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki, President, EAQAN
08:30 – 10:00	Constituting the 14th General Assembly of EAQAN Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki, President, EAQAN Opening Remarks and Report on EAQAN Activities Prof. Paul Muoki Nzioki, President, EAQAN Receiving the Report of the Executive Committee - Resolutions Dr. Amaal Kinene Nsereko, Secretary General, EAQAN Receiving Financial Status Report Dr. Jean Bosco Shema, Finance Secretary, EAQAN



	Discussion on the Reports of the Executive Committee Presentation of the Draft Strategic Plan 2026-2031 – <i>Dr. Mukirae Njihia, Dr. Mukhtar Omar and Dr. Jaha Mulema</i>
10:00 – 10:30	Health Break and Networking
Session 13	Receiving the Report of National Chapters – Focusing on achievements and challenges faced in the last year (10 min. per Chapter) + Discussion.
10:30 – 12:00	- o Burundi - o Rwanda - o Tanzania - o Uganda - o South Sudan - o Kenya - o Democratic Republic of Congo - o Somalia
Session 14	Chairperson and Returning Officer: Dr. Joseph Cosam
12:00 – 13:00	- o Election of Executive Committee - o Swearing-in the newly elected Executive Committee - o Acceptance Speech by the President Elect - o Presentation and Adoption of the Resolutions of the 14th EAQAN General Assembly - o Dissolution of the 13th General Assembly of EAQAN
13:00 – 14:00	Lunch Break and Networking
End of Day 4	
DAY 5: Friday, 11th September, 2026	
The departure of Participants at their pleasure and/ according to their flight schedules	

Keynote Speakers



Ms Siyao Wang

Ms Siyao Wang is a Project Officer for Higher Education at UNESCO's Regional Office for Eastern Africa (ROEA). Her work focuses on strengthening higher education systems across the region, with a particular emphasis on quality assurance, artificial intelligence, women in STEM, and entrepreneurship. Before joining ROEA, she worked on rural education at the global level and on education planning.



Dr. Diana Andone

Dr. Diana Andone is the Director of the Digital Education and Distance Education Department of Politehnica University of Timisoara, Romania, responsible for planning and implementing digital education and associate professor in multimedia, interactive and web technologies. Since 1998, she teaches course modules in universities from UK, France, USA, Finland, Italy, Greece. She has extensive research experience with intense publication (over 17 books, 100 research papers, 11 Best paper Awards, reviewer at 6 major journals and several other publications, associate editor at IEEE Transactions on Education, co-chair IEEE ICALT iOpenLearn) and more than 30 research and educational international projects. Dr. Andone is EDEN Senior Fellow, IEEE Education Society 2021 Distinguished Chapter Leadership Award winner, EDEN Vice-President for Communication and Communities (2018-2021), and member in IEEE Education Society Board of Governors (2021-present), in IEEE Romania Section the Educational activities Chair (2019-present) and in EUA Digital Transformation Steering Committee. She also acts in the Board of Romanian NGOs (Pentru Voi Foundation), in Timisoara 2023 European Capital of Culture Task Force and in other voluntary organisations (Rotary International).



She is passionate about the ubiquitous access to technologies and how they can be used to improve people's life. She actively supports the use of OERs, MOOCs and the open education principles, developing UniCampus.eu for training for digital skills, but also the local start-up movement, women in tech, and the digital culture. She initiated several projects for transforming communities, is invited as speaker at conferences and in the last 25 years involved in the digital education community movement in Romania, recently through the Together Online webinars and the digital culture and heritage with Spotlight Heritage Timișoara.



Prof Madara Ogot

Prof Madara Ogot is an accomplished executive and science policy leader with a strong record of advancing Africa's research and innovation agenda. He is the CEO of the UbuntuNet Alliance, where he has led in the development of digital infrastructure, secured major development partner investments, and enhanced collaboration among NRENs (<https://ubuntunet.net>). He has held senior leadership roles, including the Deputy Vice-Chancellor Research and Innovation (University of Nairobi) and Academic Affairs (Maseno University), during which he implemented institutional reforms, established robust governance and accountability systems, and developed sustainable research capacity. He has advised governments, regional bodies, and multilateral agencies, influencing

key legislation and policy frameworks that continue to shape Africa's science, technology, and innovation landscape, for example, he was a member Taskforce for the Alignment of the Higher Education, Science and Technology Sector Bills with Kenya's new Constitution that drafted the



Universities Act 2012, STI Act 2013, and the TIVET Act 2012. Ogot was also the project manager for the development of the “10 Year National Master Plan for Science and Technology Parks in Kenya”. He is currently a member of the African Higher Education Data Team of the Harmonisation, Quality Assurance, and Accreditation of African Higher Education, a flagship initiative of the European Union Global Gateway, the Governing Council of the Africa Open Science Platform and a member of the Africa AI Council thematic working groups on AI Compute Infrastructure and AI Talent and Skills.



Prof. Dr. Anca-Luminița Greere

Professor Anca Greere is an international quality assurance expert with broad ranging experience of collaborating with governments, agencies and institutions to design and successfully implement quality assurance approaches which support a positive educational experience for all stakeholders and contribute to quality cultures across educational sectors.

She holds a tenured position at the Babes-Bolyai University in Romania, formerly the Director of the European Master's Programme in Translation Studies and Terminology and an active member of the European Master's in Translation Network of the European Commission. Professor Greere also acts as Senior Advisor (External) for the British Accreditation Council and is member of the Institutional Accreditation Review Committee of the University Council of Jamaica. Previously, Professor Greere held senior



appointments with the Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education in the United Kingdom and represented the United Kingdom in WG2 of the Bologna Follow-Up Group. She has also worked extensively with the European Commission on implementing projects with relevance for the European Higher Education Area.

More recently, Professor Greere chaired the Working Group of the European Association for Quality Assurance in Higher Education (ENQA) on the Quality Assurance of Micro-credentials and edited the resulting publication. Following this work, Professor Greere undertook the design and development of a specific external quality assurance method for providers offering micro-credentials and seeking accreditation from the British Accreditation Council in the United Kingdom.

If you wish to follow Professor Greere on her YouTube channel: ***Collaborative Quality Insights for Education***, type **@AncaGreere** in the search bar on YouTube

ABSTRACTS

DESIGNING FOR AI: CURRICULUM INTEGRATION AND THE CHANGING ROLE OF QUALITY ASSURANCE IN EAST AFRICAN UNIVERSITIES

Catherine Laura Mamuli; Open University of Kenya

Raphael Ondeko Nyonje; Open University of Kenya

Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming higher education by reshaping curriculum design, content development, teaching, assessment, and institutional governance. However, quality assurance (QA) systems in many East African universities have not evolved at the same pace, creating gaps in the regulation and evaluation of AI-integrated curricula. This study examined the implications of AI for curriculum quality assurance and proposed practical strategies to strengthen QA practices in alignment with the African Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance (ASG-QA) and the Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA) framework. Specifically, the study assessed how AI is influencing curriculum design principles, the integration of AI literacy as a cross-cutting competency, AI-assisted content development and delivery, assessment validity, and governance mechanisms for AI-enabled curricula. A qualitative document



analysis design was adopted, drawing on peer-reviewed literature and institutional reports published between 2022 and 2026. Documents were systematically identified through academic databases and institutional repositories and analysed using thematic content analysis across five conceptual domains. The findings indicate that while AI adoption in higher education is accelerating, institutional quality assurance mechanisms remain underdeveloped. Significant gaps were identified in curriculum redesign, verification of AI literacy integration, quality assurance of AI-generated content, assessment validity, and governance frameworks, particularly within East African universities. The study concludes that existing QA systems require substantial reform to effectively oversee AI-integrated curricula and safeguard academic quality and integrity. Key lessons for quality assurance practitioners include the need to establish enforceable AI governance mechanisms, separate governance audits from adoption assessments, redesign assessment review systems to address AI-related risks, implement phased institutional AI maturity models, and embed explicit AI evaluation criteria into curriculum approval and periodic review processes. These measures will strengthen institutional resilience and ensure that AI integration enhances, rather than compromises, the quality and credibility of higher education in East Africa.

Key words: Artificial Intelligence (AI); AI-Integrated Curriculum; Quality Assurance; AI Governance; Higher Education in East Africa

ARCHITECTING TRUST AND AGILITY: INTEGRATING MICRO-CREDENTIALS AND RECOGNITION OF PRIOR LEARNING INTO THE KENYA NATIONAL QUALIFICATIONS FRAMEWORK FOR DYNAMIC WORKFORCE RESKILLING

Dr. Christine Kananu Gitonga, PhD
Zetech University, Kenya

The rapid transformation of the labor market during the Fourth and Fifth Industrial Revolutions has created an urgent need for agile workforce reskilling through flexible, modular education. Higher education and skills systems in the East African region need to respond rapidly to changes in the labour market through flexible module delivery, notwithstanding the caution expressed by quality assurance agencies regarding the impact on the credibility of the credentials dispensed. The case of Kenya informs us; in particular, the Kenya National Qualifications Authority (KNQA) is moving forward with the National Micro-Credentials Framework, currently engaged in the process of stakeholder validation, and is anticipating the implementation of this framework in 2026 together with the previously established recognition of prior learning quality assurance system under the Kenya National Qualifications Framework (KNQF) (KNQA,



2026a; KNQA, 2026b). Thus, a question arises that is of paramount significance for quality assurance systems in the region. Is it possible to integrate micro-credentials and recognition of prior learning systems into national qualification systems in such a manner that would provide sufficient flexibility for lifelong reskilling and enhanced value of institutional standards and degree prestige? This paper aimed to: assess the structural alignment of Kenya's National Micro-credentials Framework with the existing credit accumulation architectures of the KNQF (KNQA, 2026a); to analyze the barriers to career long reskilling among mid-career professionals in Kenya and identify how RPL can convert experiential learning into formal academic currency (KNQA, 2026b) and to propose a quality assurance model that enables Kenyan universities to integrate industry-recognized alternative credentials without diluting institutional standards or degree prestige. The investigation employed a desktop research approach that includes systematic review and thematic analysis of key policy and regulatory documents, such as the KNQF General Regulations (2025), KNQA Recognition of Prior Learning Quality Assurance Manual, National Micro-credentials Framework (KNQA, 2026a), Kenya Credit Accumulation and Transfer System (KCATS), which are triangulated with international comparable frameworks (such as Scottish SCQF, South African NQF, and the EU Council recommendation on micro-credentials). Literature was searched through Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, ScienceDirect and ERIC, with 48 studies retained for qualitative synthesis following PRISMA 2020 procedures. The findings established that effective structural alignment requires qualification-level mapping, explicit credit valuation, stackability, articulation, transfer and reliable recognition systems. Career-long reskilling is constrained by affordability, time, limited awareness, digital access, institutional rigidity and uncertainty regarding credential recognition. RPL can convert experiential learning into formal academic currency through identification, documentation, competency mapping, assessment, validation and credit award. The review further found that academic standards can be protected through clearly defined learning outcomes, academic approval, industry validation, authentic assessment, qualified assessors, internal moderation, external quality assurance and digital verification. The study concludes that micro-credentials should be integrated into, rather than operate parallel to, the KNQF, enabling workforce agility while preserving trust, institutional standards and degree prestige.

Keywords: Micro-credentials, Recognition of Prior Learning, Credit Accumulation and Transfer, National Qualifications Frameworks, Quality Assurance, Career-Long Reskilling

STUDENT MOBILITY AND CROSS-BORDER ENROLLMENT IN RWANDA'S HOSPITALITY AND TOURISM INSTITUTIONS OF HIGHER LEARNINGS: DRIVERS, EXPERIENCES, AND POLICY IMPLICATIONS

Denys Uwimpuhwe: University of Tourism Technology and Business Studies (UTB), Rwanda

Abdallah Baguma: University of Tourism Technology and Business Studies (UTB), Rwanda



Lazaro Maniraguha: University of Tourism Technology and Business Studies (UTB), Rwanda

This study examines student mobility and cross-border enrollment in Rwanda's hospitality and tourism HLIs, focusing on the factors that attract regional students, their learning experiences, and the policy implications for regional integration and skills development. Rwanda's hospitality and tourism training environment has expanded through curriculum reform, industry-linked training, and institutional investments, making it an important case for understanding regional education flows. The study adopted a mixed-methods cross-sectional design involving selected hospitality and tourism institutions in Rwanda, with data collected from students. Quantitative data identified patterns and determinants of enrollment, while qualitative data explored motivations, experiences, and institutional support systems. Data were analyzed using descriptive statistics and thematic analysis. The study is expected to show why students from East Africa choose Rwanda for hospitality and tourism training, the challenges they encounter, and how these institutions contribute to workforce development and regional integration. The findings will inform education planners, institutional managers, and tourism-sector stakeholders on how to strengthen cross-border student recruitment, support, and mobility frameworks.

Keywords: Student mobility, cross-border enrollment, hospitality education, tourism schools, Rwanda, regional integration, East Africa.

STRENGTHENING RECOGNITION, ACADEMIC MOBILITY, AND REGIONAL INTEGRATION IN THE EAST AFRICAN HIGHER EDUCATION AREA: PROGRESS, CHALLENGES, AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Jacklyne Okello Alari, PhD Kibabii University, Kenya

Linda Ouma, PhD, Kibabii University, Kenya

The establishment of the East African Common Higher Education Area (EACHEA) represents one of the most significant higher education reforms undertaken by the East African Community (EAC). By promoting harmonised qualifications frameworks, quality assurance systems, and academic mobility, the initiative seeks to enhance regional integration, improve graduate employability, and strengthen the international competitiveness of East African universities. Central to this agenda are the East African Qualifications Framework for Higher Education (EAQFHE), the Credit Accumulation and Transfer System (CATS), and the Regional Programme Accreditation Framework developed by the Inter-University Council for East Africa (IUCEA). Despite these advances, implementation remains uneven across Partner States due to differences in



national policies, institutional capacity, curriculum structures, funding, and digital infrastructure. This paper critically examines the progress, challenges, and future directions of strengthening recognition, academic mobility, and regional integration within the EACHEA. A qualitative documentary analysis was employed to review regional policy documents, legal instruments, scholarly literature, and reports published by the EAC Secretariat, IUCEA, UNESCO, the African Union (AU), national quality assurance agencies, and the World Bank. The findings reveal that while the policy architecture for regional integration is well established, practical implementation continues to face challenges, including inconsistent credit systems, varying programme structures, limited institutional capacity, and fragmented digital systems for verifying qualifications. Drawing lessons from the European Higher Education Area (EHEA) established through the Bologna Process, the paper proposes strategic interventions, including enhanced policy harmonization, expanded regional programme accreditation, strengthened institutional capacity, adoption of interoperable digital credential systems, and sustained collaboration among governments, quality assurance agencies, and universities. The study concludes that effective implementation of existing regional frameworks, coupled with digital transformation and long-term political commitment, is essential for achieving a fully operational EACHEA capable of supporting regional development, labour mobility, innovation, and sustainable economic growth.

Keywords: East African Community, East African Common Higher Education Area, qualifications recognition, academic mobility, quality assurance, credit accumulation and transfer, regional integration.

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